

IELTS BAND 7+ SCORE RESCUE

A simple guide to finding what's actually holding your IELTS score back — and what to do about it.

1 Find your problem

2 Understand why

3 Fix it

4 Practice it

5 Check progress

6 Know what's next

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IELTS Overall 8

L8.5 | R8.5 | W7 | S7

WELCOME

Let's start with the **real question**

If you're studying for IELTS right now, you've probably watched a lot of videos, done a pile of practice tests, and saved vocabulary lists you'll never open again.

And you're still thinking: **"Why isn't my score moving?"**

That doesn't mean you're not working hard. Most of the time, it means nobody has shown you where your marks are actually leaking.

THIS GUIDE HAS ONE JOB

Help you answer: "What exactly is stopping me from getting the score I want?"

No list of 100 random tips. You'll find your problem, understand why it happens, fix it with small exercises, and track whether it worked.

This guide is for you if...

- ☐ You keep getting the same score
- ☐ You practise a lot but can't see progress
- ☐ You understand English but lose marks anyway
- ☐ You're not sure what to fix first

Who's talking to you?

I'm Jubayer. My IELTS result: **Overall 8** — Listening 8.5, Reading 8.5, Writing 7, Speaking 7.

I'm telling you the 7s on purpose. Writing and Speaking are the hardest to improve alone, and I'll be honest about that.

NEXT STEP

How to use this guide (it's not what you think)

Page 3 →

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Don't read it **page 1 to the end**

Find your problem. Start there. That's the whole method.



Your map

DIAGNOSE

Find the problem

Pages 4–8

READING

5 problems, fixed

Pages 9–13

LISTENING

3 problems, fixed

Pages 14–16

WRITING

The biggest section

Pages 17–25

SPEAKING

Natural answers

Pages 26–28

TRACK

Log, plan, dashboard

Pages 29–33

The boxes you'll see again and again

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

Do you recognise yourself?

! WHY IT HAPPENS

What's really going on

→ WHAT TO DO

The fix, in steps

✎ TRY THIS

A small exercise

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

Tick what's true for you

★ TEACHING TIP

My method — not an official rule

★ TEACHING TIP

Where I talk about **official IELTS criteria** (timing, formats, scoring areas), I'll say so. Everything else is **teaching advice** from me — it works, but IELTS doesn't require it.

NEXT STEP

Where should I start?

Page 4 →

START HERE

Where should I start?

Pick the sentence that sounds most like you. Tap it (or turn to the page).



I don't know what my actual problem is

→ Start with the 10-minute diagnostic

Page 6



I study a lot, but my score isn't moving

Page 7



I understand Reading but keep getting answers wrong

Page 9



I understand the Listening audio but lose marks

Page 14



I keep getting 6 / 6.5 in Writing

Page 22



I know English, but my Speaking score is low

Page 26



My scores change wildly between mock tests

Page 8

**START HERE**

Two or more of these sound like you? Don't panic. Take the diagnostic. It will tell you which one is costing you the most marks — and that's the one you fix first.

NEXT STEP

Find your problem: the decision tree

Page 5 →

FIND YOUR PROBLEM

Which one sounds like **you**?

Look at your last 3 mock tests. Where do you lose the most marks?

IF...

Reading: you understand the passage, but answers are still wrong

→ **Go to page 9**

IF...

Reading: you run out of time

→ **Go to page 10**

IF...

Writing: full essays, but always 6.0–6.5

→ **Go to page 22**

IF...

Writing Task 1 feels random and low

→ **Go to page 25**

IF...

Speaking: comfortable, but Part 2 runs out of ideas

→ **Go to page 27**

IF...

Speaking: answers are too short

→ **Go to page 26**

IF...

Listening: mistakes feel random

→ **Go to page 14**

IF...

Listening: one miss and you panic

→ **Go to page 16**

I have no idea what's holding me back

→ **Take the full diagnostic, page 6**

→ **WHAT TO DO**

More than one applies? Pick the section where your **band score is lowest**. If they're equal, pick the one you avoid practising. That's usually the real one.

NEXT STEP

Take the 10-minute diagnostic

Page 6 →

START HERE · DIAGNOSTIC

The 10-minute diagnostic

Tick every sentence that's true for you. Be honest — nobody is marking this.

READING

- ☐ I run out of time on Passage 3
- ☐ I find the right place but pick the wrong answer
- ☐ True/False/Not Given or Matching Headings hurts me
- ☐ I lose marks on answers I felt sure about

LISTENING

- ☐ I miss answers while thinking about the last one
- ☐ I hear it, but spell it or write it wrongly
- ☐ Speakers change their mind and I fall for it
- ☐ One missed answer makes me panic

WRITING

- ☐ My essay sounds fine but gets 6.0–6.5
- ☐ I'm not sure I've answered every part of the question
- ☐ My paragraphs feel like a list of points
- ☐ The same grammar mistakes keep coming back

SPEAKING

- ☐ My answers are short
- ☐ I go blank in Part 2
- ☐ I sound memorised or unnatural
- ☐ I can't hear my own repeated mistakes

Skill	My ticks	Start on
Reading	_____ / 4	page 9
Listening	_____ / 4	page 14
Writing	_____ / 4	page 22
Speaking	_____ / 4	page 26

→ WHAT TO DO

Most ticks = start there. Tied? Start with your lowest band score. Got 3–4 ticks in two skills? Start with Writing or Speaking — they're hardest to fix alone, so they need the most time.

SECTION 1 • DIAGNOSE

"I study a lot, but my score **isn't moving**"

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

You do three Reading tests every week. You get 29/40. You do another test. 29/40. Another one. 28.

The problem may not be lack of practice. You may be practising the same mistake 20 times.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

29/40 in Academic Reading is usually around Band 6.5 — just a mark or two under 7 (the exact conversion changes slightly between tests). Those last marks don't come from more tests. They come from understanding *why* you lost the marks you lost.

Five things students mix up

It's...	What it means	Does it raise your score?
Studying more	More hours or more tests	Only if you fix something along the way
Practising	Doing a test or a task	Builds the habit — and the mistakes
Reviewing	Finding <i>why</i> each mark was lost	Yes. This is where improvement starts
Feedback	Someone (or something) shows you what you can't see	Yes — especially in Writing and Speaking
Studying correctly	Practice → review → fix one thing → try again	Yes. This is the goal

□ CHECK YOURSELF

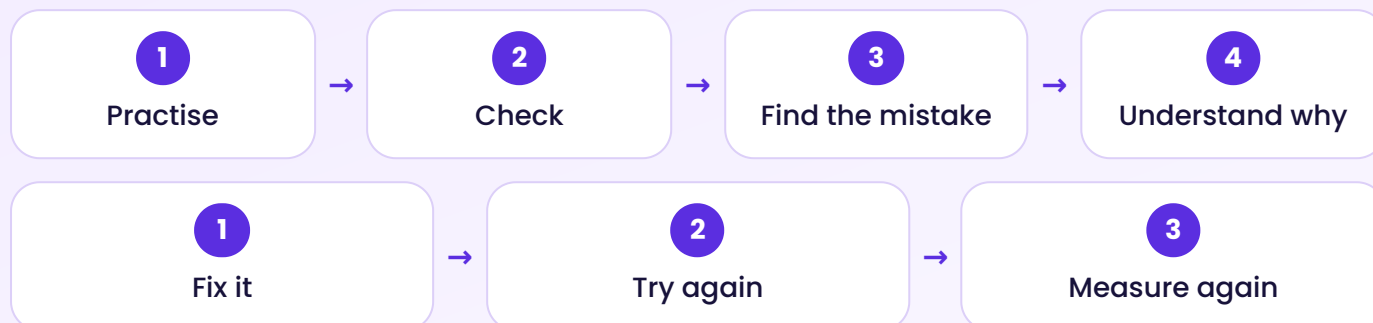
- ☐ Do I know *why* I lost each mark in my last test?
- ☐ Could I name my three most repeated mistakes right now?

Two "no"s? That's your answer. Keep going.

SECTION 1 • THE LOOP

The loop that **actually** raises your score

Most students stop at step 1. Improvement lives in steps 2 to 7.



! WHY IT HAPPENS

Why do scores swing between mocks?

Usually it's one of three things: (1) timing – you rush one test and not the next, (2) careless errors that appear randomly, (3) one question type you're weak at that happened to appear more this time. The loop finds which one it is.

→ WHAT TO DO

- **Use the same conditions** for every mock: timed, no pausing, no dictionary.
- **Review before you do another test.** One test, properly reviewed, beats three rushed ones.
- **Change one thing at a time** so you know what worked.

✎ TRY THIS

Take your last test. Spend 20 minutes on only this:

- Circle every wrong answer.
- Next to each, write one word: **Knowledge**, **Strategy** or **Careless** (explained on page 13).
- Count each type. The biggest number is where to start.

▶ START HERE

No test to review? Take the diagnostic on page 6, or jump to your section from page 4.

READING · PROBLEM 1

"I understand the passage, but I still get questions wrong"

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Understanding the *general idea* isn't enough. IELTS asks about specific details, and the passage rarely uses the same words as the question. You read it, it feels fine — but you can't prove your answer from the text.

Three skills that fix this

1

Pick keywords



2

Predict the paraphrase



3

Locate the exact spot

QUESTION

"The number of tourists visiting the island has increased dramatically."

KEYWORDS

tourists, island, increased (not "number", "the", "has")

IN THE TEXT

"Visitor arrivals on the island have more than doubled since 2010."

NOTE

tourists → visitor arrivals · increased dramatically → more than doubled

→ WHAT TO DO

1. **Underline 2–3 keywords** — names, numbers, specific nouns. Skip small words.
2. **Guess a paraphrase** for each: tourists = visitors, travellers.
3. **Scan for the idea**, not the exact word. Mark the sentence.
4. **Read one sentence before and after** it, then answer. The trap is often right next door.

🔑 TRY THIS

Match the phrase to its paraphrase (key on page 33)

- | | |
|--------------------------|--|
| a) a sharp rise | 1) received a lot of negative comments |
| b) in the early stages | 2) reduced |
| c) was widely criticised | 3) a dramatic increase |
| d) cut back on | 4) at the beginning |

NEXT STEP

Reading: where your time disappears

Page 10 →

READING · PROBLEM 2

"I waste too much time"

Reading is 60 minutes, 3 passages, 40 questions. There's no extra time to copy answers over.

Where time disappears	What it looks like
Reading every word first	You finish the passage with 40 minutes gone for 2 passages' worth of effort
Fighting one hard question	Four minutes on one mark
Not reading the instructions	You write 3 words when the limit is 2 — a wasted answer
Over-checking early answers	You re-read Passage 1 and run short on Passage 3

✓ DO THIS

- Read the questions **first**
- Skim the passage for structure (1–2 min)
- Mark a hard question and **move on after about a minute**
- Write every answer clearly as you go
- Guess if you must. There's no negative marking, so **never leave a blank**

✗ NOT THIS

- Reading the whole passage like a story
- Looking up every unknown word
- Staying on a question out of pride
- Spending 25 minutes on Passage 1 "to be safe"
- Leaving blanks "to come back to"

★ TEACHING TIP

A common guide is about **20 minutes per passage**. That's my teaching suggestion, not an official rule. If Passage 3 is your weakest, try **17 / 20 / 23** and see.

📝 TRY THIS

Do one passage with a timer. After each question group, write down the minute you finished. Your slowest group is where your time is going.

READING · PROBLEM 3

"True / False / Not Given confuses me"

TRUE

The passage says the **same thing**

FALSE

The passage says the **opposite**

NOT GIVEN

The passage **doesn't say**, even if it sounds logical

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Students lose marks because they use **what they know**, not **what the passage says**. If it sounds right in real life, your brain says "True". IELTS only cares about the text.

PASSAGE (my own mini-example)

"The library opens at 9 a.m. on weekdays and is closed on Sundays. Membership is free for students."

Statement	Answer	Why
The library is open every day.	FALSE	Closed on Sundays. Opposite.
Students pay nothing to join.	TRUE	"Free" = pay nothing.
The library has over 10,000 books.	NOT GIVEN	Nothing about books.
It opens at 9 a.m. on Saturdays.	NOT GIVEN	Weekdays and Sundays are covered — Saturday isn't.

→ WHAT TO DO

Ask yourself: **"Can I point to the exact words that prove it?"**

No words → **Not Given**. Same meaning → **True**. Opposite meaning → **False**.

Watch for tiny words: *only, all, always, never, some, most*. One word can flip the answer.

🔑 TRY THIS

"The café opens at 8 a.m. every day except Monday. Coffee costs more after 6 p.m."

1) The café is open on Tuesdays. 2) Coffee is cheaper in the evening. 3) The café serves breakfast.

Answers: page 33

READING · PROBLEM 4

"Matching Headings destroys my score"

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

What most students do: read the heading, spot one matching word in a paragraph, pick it. That's the trap. The question designers know you'll do this.

× COMMON MISTAKES

- Matching by **one word** instead of the main idea
- Choosing a heading about a **detail**, not the whole paragraph
- Forgetting there are **more headings than paragraphs**
- Reading the full passage first

✓ BETTER PROCESS

1. Underline the **main idea** of each heading
2. Read the paragraph's **first and last sentences**
3. Ask: "What is this **mostly about**?"
4. Do easy ones first; cross out used headings
5. Check your leftovers last

QUESTION

Heading: "The cost of building new roads"

MISTAKE

The paragraph says "cost" once, so you choose it.

WHY

The paragraph is mostly about how new roads reduce traffic. "Cost" was a side detail.

BETTER

Choose the heading that matches the **whole paragraph's** main idea, not one word.

🔗 TRY THIS

"Many city councils now offer free bicycles for short trips. Residents unlock a bike with a phone app and leave it at any station. Early results suggest fewer people drive to work, and air quality near the centre has slightly improved."

Which heading fits? A) Why cycling is dangerous B) A bike-sharing scheme and its early effects C) The history of the bicycle

Answer: page 33

NEXT STEP

Reading: silly mistakes and your checklist

Page 13 →

READING · PROBLEM 5

"I keep making silly mistakes"

"Silly" mistakes usually have a reason. Name the type, and you can fix it.

Type	What it means	How to tell	Fix
K Knowledge	You didn't know the word or didn't understand the text	Even with extra time, you'd still get it wrong	Learn the word / idea in context
S Strategy	You knew enough but used the wrong method	Extra time would help; or you ran out of time	Change your method (pp.9–12)
C Careless	You knew the answer and wrote it wrongly	You see it instantly when you review	Slow down at the writing step; check word limits

 TRY THIS

Error log, mini version. For every wrong answer, add one line:

Q	Type (K/S/C)	What happened
27	S	Chose False — passage never mentioned it (should be NG)

The full printable version is on page 29.

YOUR READING CHECKLIST

- ☐ I read the questions before the passage
- ☐ I underline 2–3 keywords per question
- ☐ I guess a paraphrase before I scan
- ☐ I answer from the text — not from what I know
- ☐ I move on after about a minute and come back
- ☐ I check the word limit on every gap-fill
- ☐ I never leave a blank
- ☐ I know my biggest mistake type (K, S or C)

LISTENING · PROBLEMS 1–2

“I knew the answer, but I missed it”

Listening is 4 sections, 40 questions, and you hear the recording **once**. So the real skill is being ready *before* the audio starts.

“I knew the answer, but I missed it.”

You weren't looking at the right question when it came.

“I heard the word, but wrote the wrong thing.”

Spelling, plurals or numbers — see the next page.

“I was still on Question 17 when the audio was on 19.”

You're stuck in the past. Let it go.

“I panic when I miss one answer.”

One miss turns into three. Page 16.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

The speaker doesn't wait. The questions are in the same order as the audio, so if you're **looking at the wrong line**, you will miss the answer even if you understood every word.

→ WHAT TO DO

1. **Use the preview time.** Read the next questions *before* the audio starts, not after.
2. **Underline keywords** in the next 2–3 questions, not just the current one.
3. **Predict the type of answer:** a number? a name? a place? an adjective?
4. **Missed one? It's gone.** Write a guess and focus on the next question. This is my advice, but it saves more marks than anything else on this page.

📝 TRY THIS

Predict before you listen. What kind of answer is each gap?

- 1) The museum is closed on ____ 2) Cost: £____ 3) Guide's name: ____ 4) Meet at the ____ entrance

Answers: page 33

NEXT STEP

Listening: distractors, spelling, numbers

Page 15 →

LISTENING · PROBLEMS 3–4

“I heard the word, but still lost the **mark**”

Most Listening marks are lost *after* you understand. Check these before you write.

Distractors: the speaker changes their mind

AUDIO

“The meeting is on Tuesday — oh, sorry, Wednesday the 14th.”

MISTAKE

You hear “Tuesday” first and write it down.

BETTER

Wait for the **final** version. Listen for corrections: *sorry, actually, no wait, I mean, rather.*

Your pre-writing check

Check	Example	Why it costs marks
Word limit	“NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS”	Three words = wrong answer
Spelling	environment, February, accommodation	A misspelled answer is marked wrong
Plural or singular	“two passport _____”	“photograph” ≠ “photographs”
Numbers	fifteen vs fifty, 13 vs 30	The stress is on a different syllable
Dates / units	12th vs 2nd, £ vs %	Wrong format or missing unit

 TRY THIS

Spot the error. What went wrong in each?

- 1) Audio: “fifteen pounds” → student wrote **£50**
- 2) Audio: “two passport photographs” → student wrote **passport photograph**
- 3) Audio: “Tuesday... sorry, Wednesday” → student wrote **Tuesday**
- 4) Student wrote **enviroment**

Answers: page 33

 WHAT TO DO

Build a spelling list. Every time you misspell a word in practice, add it. Ask a friend to read 10 words from the list, and write them without looking. Do this twice a week.

NEXT STEP

Listening: concentration and review

Page 16 →

LISTENING · PROBLEMS 5–6

"I lose focus, and I don't review properly"

! WHY IT HAPPENS

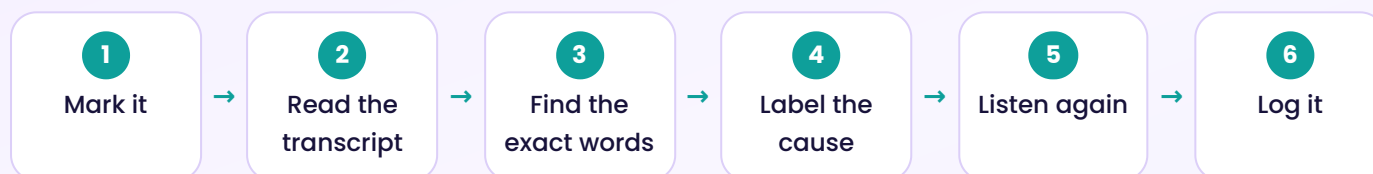
Concentration usually drops in the middle of a section, right when you're still thinking about a missed answer. That's why the damage spreads.

→ WHAT TO DO

Your panic plan, 3 steps:

1. Write a guess. A blank is a guaranteed zero.
2. Take one breath.
3. Find the **current** question in the booklet with your pen.

How to review a Listening test properly



Cause	What it means	Fix
Didn't hear it	The words were too fast or unclear	Listen again with the transcript; repeat the phrase aloud
Heard, misunderstood	You knew the words but missed the meaning	Note the paraphrase in your log
Distractor	You wrote the first answer	Listen for correction words
Spelling / format	Right answer, wrong writing	Add to your spelling list
Lost my place	You were on the wrong question	Practise reading ahead

★ TEACHING TIP

Don't rewind during practice tests. In the real exam you get one play. Practise that way, then use the transcript for review.

YOUR LISTENING ERROR CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ I read the next questions in the preview time | ☐ I let a missed answer go immediately |
| ☐ I underline keywords and predict the answer type | ☐ I review with the transcript, not just the score |
| ☐ I wait for the final version of an answer | ☐ I keep a spelling list |
| ☐ I check word limit, spelling and plurals | ☐ I know my most common cause: heard / meaning / distractor / spelling / lost |

NEXT STEP

Writing: why your essay stays at 6.0–6.5

Page 17 →

WRITING · START HERE

You read it again. It sounds good. Then you get 6.0 or 6.5

"What exactly am I doing wrong?"

Here's what's happening. You're judging your essay by how it *sounds*. The examiner judges it by **four specific things**. Your essay might be strong in three and weak in one — and that one holds the whole score down.

Official criterion	In everyday words
Task Achievement (Task 1) Task Response (Task 2)	Did you actually answer everything the question asked?
Coherence and Cohesion	Can I follow your ideas easily from one sentence and paragraph to the next?
Lexical Resource	Are your words accurate and natural, not just difficult?
Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Do you use a variety of sentences, and are they mostly correct?

4

criteria, each worth the **same** (25%)

2×

Task 2 counts **twice** as much as Task 1

60

minutes total. Minimums: 150 words (Task 1), 250 (Task 2)

All of the above is official. My timing split of about 20 + 40 minutes is a teaching suggestion.



WHAT TO DO

Over the next 8 pages, you'll look at each criterion in plain language, with a bad example and a better one. Then you'll find which one is holding you back.



START HERE

Impatient? Jump to "Why you keep getting 6.0–6.5" on page 22, then come back for the explanations.

NEXT STEP

Writing: Task Response

Page 18 →

WRITING · TASK RESPONSE

“Did I actually answer **everything** the question asked?”

EXAMPLE QUESTION (original)

“Some people think children should start learning a foreign language at primary school. Others believe it is better to start later. Discuss both views and give your opinion.”

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

Your essay is well written, but it only talks about why early learning is good. The other view is missing, or your opinion is hidden. **That is a Task Response problem — and good English can't fix it.**

This question has 3 parts	A weak answer	A stronger answer
View 1: start early	Covered well	Covered, with a reason and example
View 2: start later	One vague sentence: “Some people disagree.”	A full paragraph with its own reasons
Your opinion	“It depends.” Or only in the last line	Stated in the introduction, supported, repeated in the conclusion

WEAK INTRO

“Learning a foreign language is important. Many people have different opinions about this.”

WHY

It repeats the topic. It doesn't show you'll cover both views or give an opinion.

BETTER

“While some argue that primary school is the ideal time to start a foreign language, others prefer a later start. I believe that early learning is more effective, although it should be fun rather than formal.”

✎ TRY THIS

Split any question into parts. Underline: *discuss both views* (2 parts) + *give your opinion* (1 part) = 3 paragraphs' worth of content. Write the number of parts in the margin before you plan.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

- ☐ Did I answer **every** part of the question?
- ☐ Is my opinion **clear** and the **same** throughout?
- ☐ Does every paragraph answer the question, or just the topic?

WRITING · COHERENCE & COHESION

“How does this sentence connect to the last one?”

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

If I read your paragraph and have to stop and think, “How does this sentence connect to the last one?”, your paragraph probably needs clearer organisation.

✗ FEELS LIKE A LIST

*Technology is useful for education.
Students can find information quickly.
Many students spend too much time on phones.
Online classes are flexible.
Teachers need training.*

✓ FEELS LIKE ONE IDEA

Technology makes it much easier for students to find information. A task that once took an afternoon in a library can now be done in minutes. As a result, students can spend more time understanding ideas instead of searching for them.

What changed?

Weak paragraph	Stronger paragraph
5 different ideas in 5 sentences	One main idea, developed
Each sentence stands alone	Each sentence answers “so what?” about the last
No linking logic	Links show logic: <i>as a result, however, by contrast</i>

→ WHAT TO DO

A simple paragraph pattern: Main point → Explain it → Example → Link back to the question.
That’s my teaching method, not an official rule.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Many students add *Moreover, Furthermore, In addition* to every sentence and think that fixes it. It doesn’t. Linking words only help when the **ideas** are already in a logical order. Use them where the logic needs them.

🔧 TRY THIS

Take one of your old paragraphs. Count the ideas. If it’s more than one, split it, or cut the extra ideas. Read it again: does each sentence follow naturally?

WRITING · LEXICAL RESOURCE

“Difficult words” is not the same as good vocabulary

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

If you know 2,000 words but keep using the same 100 incorrectly, learning another 500 words probably isn't your biggest problem.

✗ TRYING TOO HARD

“Pedagogical paradigms necessitate substantial modification.”

Sounds clever. Means little. Hard to follow.

✓ PRECISE AND NATURAL

“Teaching methods need to change.”

Clear. Exact. Easy to score well.

What actually matters

Unnatural	Natural	The pattern
do a mistake	make a mistake	Words that “go together” (collocations)
big traffic	heavy traffic	Same
learn knowledge	gain knowledge	Same
many researches	a lot of research	Uncountable nouns have no plural

→ WHAT TO DO

Learn words in context, not in lists. For each new word, write: the word + a phrase it goes with + **your own** sentence. Five words learned this way beat 50 words on a list.

✎ TRY THIS

Replace “important” in each sentence with something more precise:

1) It is important to save money. 2) A balanced diet is important for health. 3) Education is important for finding a job.

Sample answers: page 33

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

- ☐ Do I use the same word 3+ times in one paragraph?
- ☐ Do I check if a word sounds natural with the words around it?
- ☐ Do I spell my common words correctly?

WRITING · GRAMMAR

“Learn more grammar” is useless advice. Find your **repeat offenders**

Most students make the same 4–6 errors again and again. Fix those first. Don't try to learn all grammar.

Pattern	Mistake	Fix
Missing article	Government should invest more.	The government should invest more.
Subject–verb agreement	The number of students are rising.	The number ... is rising.
Comma splice	Many people use phones, they don't read.	...phones, but they don't read. (or a full stop)
Uncountable noun	These informations are useful.	This information is useful.
Word form	The economy growth ...	The economic growth...
Incomplete sentence	Although many people agree.	Although many people agree, others disagree.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

The official Band 7 descriptor talks about **a variety of complex structures** and **frequent error-free sentences**. So you need *some* complex sentences, and *most of your sentences* must be correct. Accuracy matters more than showing off.

→ WHAT TO DO

Find your top 3. Look at your last 3 essays. Highlight every grammar error. Group them. The 3 biggest groups are your repeat offenders. Write them on your dashboard (page 32).

🔧 TRY THIS

Fix each sentence: 1) Government should spend more on education. 2) The number of students are rising. 3) Many people use phones, they don't read books. 4) This informations is useful.

Sample answers: page 33

NEXT STEP

Writing: why you keep getting 6.0–6.5

Page 22 →

WRITING · START HERE

Why you keep getting 6.0–6.5

Tick what's true. The group with the **most ticks** is your bottleneck.

A · Task Response

Am I really answering?

- ☐ I'm not sure I covered every part
- ☐ My opinion is vague or appears late
- ☐ My examples are general ("many people...")

B · Coherence

Can the reader follow me?

- ☐ Paragraphs feel like a list of points
- ☐ I use linking words, but ideas still jump
- ☐ My paragraphs have 2–3 different ideas

C · Vocabulary

Is it accurate and natural?

- ☐ I repeat the same words a lot
- ☐ I use "big words" that sound odd
- ☐ I make word-choice or spelling errors

D · Grammar

Is it varied and correct?

- ☐ The same 3–4 errors keep coming back
- ☐ I use only simple sentences to stay "safe"
- ☐ My complex sentences often have mistakes

▶ START HERE

Mostly A? Rewrite your introduction and plan. **B?** Go to page 19. **C?** Page 20. **D?** Page 21.

No clear winner? Choose Task Response first — it's the criterion most often hurting essays that "sound fine".

! WHY IT HAPPENS

An honest note: I can't mark your essay from a checklist. This tells you where to look. If you can't tell whether a paragraph is clear or a sentence is correct, that's exactly when outside feedback helps (page 34).

NEXT STEP

Writing: fix one problem at a time

Page 23 →

WRITING · FIX IT

Fix your essay one problem at a time



! WHY IT HAPPENS

Students try to fix everything in every essay, and fix nothing. One goal per essay is slower for one essay, faster for your score.

The 5-minute writing self-check

Do this after every practice essay. One minute each.

Min	Check	What to look for
1	Did I answer every part?	Underline each part of the question. Find it in your essay.
2	Is my opinion clear?	Highlight it in the intro and conclusion. Do they match?
3	One idea per paragraph?	Write each paragraph's main idea in 5 words.
4	Repeated words?	Circle any word used 3+ times. Replace one.
5	Repeat offenders?	Check articles, subject-verb, plurals, commas. Read the last paragraph aloud.

📌 TRY THIS

Right now: take your latest essay and do only the 1-minute check #1. Did you answer every part? That takes 60 seconds and often finds the problem.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

- ☐ I know which ONE criterion I'm fixing this week
- ☐ I wrote down the specific thing I'll change
- ☐ I did the 5-minute check on my last essay

NEXT STEP

Writing: before → after

Page 24 →

WRITING • BEFORE → AFTER

Same idea. **Much** better paragraph.

QUESTION (original)

"Some people think governments should spend money on public transport rather than building new roads. To what extent do you agree or disagree?"

✗ BEFORE

Public transport is very good for the city. Many people can use it, it is cheap. Also roads are not good because there are many cars. Cars make pollution and that is bad. So government should build more bus and train.

✓ AFTER

Investing in public transport benefits a city far more than building new roads. A single metro train can carry thousands of commuters who would otherwise drive, so fewer cars compete for the same road space. This reduces both traffic jams and air pollution, which are two of the biggest problems in large cities. By contrast, new roads often attract even more cars, so congestion returns within a few years.

What changed — and why it helps

#	Change	Which criterion
1	Opening sentence answers the question directly: <i>"benefits... far more than..."</i>	Task Response
2	"It is cheap" → a specific reason: one train carries <i>thousands</i> , so fewer cars	Task Response
3	Comma splice fixed. Two ideas are now properly joined	Grammar
4	"Cars make pollution and that is bad" → <i>reduces traffic jams and air pollution</i>	Vocabulary
5	<i>By contrast</i> shows the logic: public transport vs. new roads	Coherence
6	"Government should build more bus and train" → removed; the paragraph stays on one idea	Coherence / Grammar

✎ TRY THIS

Write your own "before" paragraph on this question. Then rewrite it using the 6 changes above. Compare. What changed the most?

WRITING · TASK 1 (ACADEMIC)

"I describe every number and still score low"

? YOU MIGHT HAVE THIS PROBLEM

Task 1 isn't a maths test. If you list every number, the examiner can't see whether you understand the **main picture**.

Chart (my own example): % of households with internet access

	2005	2020
Country A	20	90
Country B	40	75
Country C	10	60

Paragraph

What goes in it

1 • Introduction	Say what the chart shows, in your own words
2 • Overview	2 big trends, no detailed numbers
3 • Details	Group and compare the key features, with numbers
4 • Details	The other group or period

BAD

"Country A was 20, Country B was 40, Country C was 10 in 2005..." (just reading numbers)

BETTER OVERVIEW

"Overall, internet access rose in all three countries. Country A saw the biggest increase and overtook Country B, which started highest."

WHY

It shows the pattern and a comparison without drowning in data.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

The official Task Achievement criterion looks for a **clear overview** of the main trends or differences. Many students skip it, and that's a common reason Task 1 stays low.

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Did I write an overview? | ☐ Are my numbers accurate? |
| ☐ No opinions or reasons I made up? | ☐ Did I compare, not just list? |
| | ☐ At least 150 words? |

A conclusion isn't needed if you have a clear overview.

NEXT STEP

Speaking: fix your problem

Page 26 →

SPEAKING · PROBLEMS 1–3

"I speak English every day, so why is my Speaking score only 6.5?"

"I know what to say, but I suddenly forget everything."

"I keep giving short answers."

"I try to sound advanced and end up unnatural."

"I don't know what to say for Part 2."

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Everyday English is relaxed and short. The Speaking test (11–14 minutes, 3 parts, recorded) asks you to **develop ideas, stay organised and sound natural under pressure**. Officially, you're scored equally on: Fluency and Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy, and Pronunciation.

Part 1: extend your answers (my method)

1

Answer



2

Reason



3

Example or detail

QUESTION

"Do you like cooking?"

SHORT

"Yes, I like it."

EXTENDED

"Yes, I do, mostly at weekends. It helps me relax after a busy week, and I enjoy trying new dishes — last week I made a fish curry for my family for the first time."

NOTE

Answer + **reason** + **small example**. That's 2–3 sentences. Not a speech.

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Too long is also a problem. In Part 1, if every answer is 30 seconds, you'll run out of time and sound rehearsed. Aim for 2–3 sentences, then stop.

🔊 TRY THIS

Try it now. Answer these three out loud in 2–3 sentences each:

1) Do you enjoy travelling? 2) What do you do in your free time? 3) Is your hometown a good place to live?

Record yourself. Did every answer have an answer, a reason and a detail?

NEXT STEP

Speaking: Part 2 framework

Page 27 →

SPEAKING · PART 2

"I don't know what to say for Part 2"

Officially: you get a cue card, **1 minute to prepare**, then speak for **1–2 minutes**.

A 4-part framework (my method)



CUE CARD (original)

Describe a time you helped someone.

You should say: who you helped · what you did · why they needed help · and how you felt.

NOTES

Write 4 words, not sentences: **cousin · bags · station · proud**

START

"I'd like to talk about the time I helped my cousin at the railway station."

DETAIL

What you did, where you were, one clear moment

WHY

"She was alone with heavy bags, and I knew how stressful that feels."

FINISH

"Looking back, I felt proud — it was a small thing, but it mattered."

! WHY IT HAPPENS

Don't memorise scripts. Examiners can tell, and rehearsed answers don't fit the question you actually get. Practise the **structure**, not the words.

🔧 TRY THIS

TRY THIS NOW (5 minutes).

1. Pick one question below. Prepare for **1 minute** (4 words only).
2. Speak for **2 minutes**. Record it.
3. Listen. Mark every place you **stopped, repeated yourself or abandoned an idea**.
Describe a place you visited · a person you admire · a time you learned something new · a useful object you own

NEXT STEP

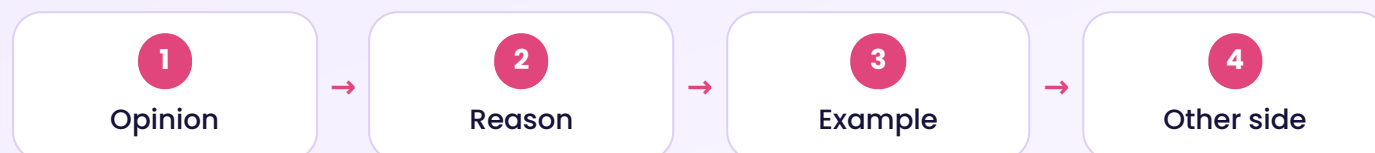
Speaking: Part 3 and everything else

Page 28 →

SPEAKING · PART 3 + EXTRAS

Part 3, thinking in real time, and sounding natural

Part 3 is a discussion (4–5 minutes). The questions are more abstract.



Problem	What to do
Unfamiliar question	Buy a second: "That's an interesting question — I think it depends on..." Then give a reason. Don't panic-silence.
Thinking in real time	Speak in short chunks. Pauses to think are normal. Repeating yourself isn't.
Vocabulary	Use words you can use <i>naturally</i> . One accurate phrase beats three forced ones.
Pronunciation	Clear matters more than "British" or "American". Focus on word stress, rhythm, and ending sounds.
Grammar	Record yourself. Find 2 repeated errors. Fix only those two for a week.
Memorised answers	My advice: don't. They sound different from your normal speech. Practise ideas, not scripts.

TRY THIS

Part 3 practice questions (original):

1) Why do some people prefer working from home? 2) How has technology changed the way people travel? 3) Should schools teach practical life skills? 4) Do you think people are more or less patient than before?

CHECK YOURSELF

☐ I give an **opinion + reason + example**

☐ I don't freeze at unfamiliar questions

☐ I recorded myself this week

☐ I know my top 2 repeated errors

TRACK • THE MISTAKE LOG

"If you don't know why you got it wrong, it will come back"

Print this page. Fill one row for every mistake you want to stop repeating — in any skill.

[illegible]

→ WHAT TO DO

Review this log **once a week**. Highlight any mistake that appears twice. That's your next thing to fix.

NEXT STEP Stop doing this

Page 30 →

TRACK · STOP DOING THIS

Stop this. Do this instead.

STOP THIS**Endless mock tests**

More tests, same mistakes.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Analyse every mistake**

One reviewed test beats three rushed ones.

STOP THIS**Collecting random vocabulary**

Lists you never use.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Learn useful words in context**

Word + phrase + your own sentence.

STOP THIS**Memorising Speaking answers**

They sound fake and don't fit the question.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Practise building answers**

Answer + reason + example, every time.

STOP THIS**Watching IELTS tips for hours**

Feels like studying. Isn't.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Learn one strategy. Use it today.**

Then watch another.

STOP THIS**Writing essay after essay without feedback**

Repeating the same weakness.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Find the recurring weakness first**

Then write with one clear goal.

STOP THIS**Trying to fix everything at once**

Slow progress everywhere.

**DO THIS INSTEAD****Fix your biggest bottleneck first**

Then the next one.

CHECK YOURSELF

Which of the six do you do most? Circle it. That's your first thing to change this week.

NEXT STEP

Your 14-day Score Rescue plan

Page 31 →

TRACK · 14-DAY PLAN

Your 14-day Score Rescue plan

Realistic: **about 45–60 minutes a day**. No 8-hour days. One main weakness.

Day	Today's goal	Do this	Time	Check this	Don't worry about
1	Find your biggest weakness	Take the diagnostic (p.6). Review your last mock.	45 min	Weakness is written on your dashboard	Other skills
2	Learn the fix	Read your section. Do one exercise.	45 min	You can explain the fix in 2 sentences	Full tests
3	Practise it	One timed task on this weakness only.	60 min	Did you use the new method every time?	The score
4	Review mistakes	Fill the Mistake Log for Day 3.	40 min	Every mistake has a "why"	Being perfect
5	Fix the repeat mistake	Drill your top mistake (5 in a row correct).	45 min	5 correct in a row	Speed
6	Second problem, lightly	30 min on your 2nd biggest problem.	30 min	It's on your dashboard	Mastering it
7	Rest + weekly review	Read the log. What repeated?	20 min	You know what to fix next week	Studying more
8	Practise again	New material, same weakness.	60 min	Fewer repeats of the same mistake?	New tips
9	Review	Update the Mistake Log.	40 min	Types counted: K / S / C	Perfection
10	Targeted drill	Rewrite a paragraph or re-record Part 2.	45 min	Is it better than before?	Length
11	Test conditions	One full section, timed.	60 min	Timing and focus	The score
12	Deep review	Find patterns in Day 11 mistakes.	45 min	Which pattern repeats?	Other topics
13	Mini mock	One full skill, or Writing Task 2 + self-check.	60 min	Compare with Day 3	Result day
14	Measure and decide	Compare with Day 1. Pick the next 14-day goal.	30 min	Did one thing improve?	Reaching the target in 14 days

TRACK · DASHBOARD

My IELTS dashboard

Print it. Fill it in. Stick it where you study.

My target score

My current score

Listening

Reading

Writing

Speaking

My biggest problem

My second biggest problem

The mistake I repeat most

What I need to stop doing

What I need to practise

My next mock (date + skill)

My target for the next 14 days

NEXT STEP

Answer keys for the exercises

Page 33 →

TRACK · ANSWER KEYS

Answer keys

READING

p.9 Paraphrase: a→3, b→4, c→1, d→2

p.11 Café: 1 True (open every day except Monday) · 2 False (costs more) · 3 Not Given

p.12 Headings: B. It covers the whole paragraph. A (danger) isn't mentioned; C (history) isn't either.

LISTENING

p.14 Predict: 1 a day (e.g., Monday) · 2 a number (price) · 3 a name (spelling matters) · 4 a word like *north*, *main*, *side*

p.15 Errors: 1 *fifteen* ≠ *fifty*; answer £15 · 2 missing plural: *passport photographs* · 3 distractor: final answer is *Wednesday* · 4 spelling: *environment*

WRITING (sample answers — others are possible)

p.20 Vocabulary: 1 It is *wise* to save money. · 2 A balanced diet is *essential* for health. · 3 Education *plays a key role* in finding a job.

p.21 Grammar: 1 *The* government should spend more on education. · 2 The number of students *is* rising. · 3 Many people use phones, *but* they don't read books. · 4 This *information* is useful.

★ TEACHING TIP

Got most of these right? Good. That's your cue to practise on **real test material** and log your mistakes. If some were wrong, re-read that page before moving on.

NEXT STEP · BE HONEST

When self-study works — and when you need feedback

→ WHAT TO DO

You can improve a lot by yourself — especially when you know what your problem is and how to fix it. That's what this guide is built for. If you finish it and your score rises, great. You didn't need anything else.

Self-study works well when...	Outside feedback helps most when...
You know your problem (Reading and Listening mistakes show in your score)	Writing: you can't see your own errors in an essay
You review every mistake	Speaking: you can't hear your own mistakes
You stay consistent without reminders	Plateau: same score for months, and you don't know why
You can follow a plan alone	Repeated mistakes: you fix one, another appears
Your target is close to your current band	No accountability: good plans, but you keep stopping
	Hard to diagnose: you can't find the real cause

☐ CHECK YOURSELF

Tick the ones that sound like you:

- ☐ I've been stuck at the same score for 2+ months
- ☐ I can't tell if my essays or answers are really improving
- ☐ I know what to do but I don't do it consistently
- ☐ I want someone to correct my Writing and Speaking

3 or more? Outside feedback will likely save you time. 0–1? Keep going on your own.

NEXT STEP

From this guide to a full program

Page 35 →

NEXT STEP · WHAT COMES AFTER THIS GUIDE

This guide gives you the plan. **Doing it is a different job.**

Knowing what to do and actually doing it consistently are two different things.

THIS FREE GUIDE

Gives you...

- ✓ Diagnosis
- ✓ Direction
- ✓ Practice tools
- ✓ Checklists
- ✓ An action plan

IELTS DECODED MENTORSHIP

Adds...

- ✓ Structure
- ✓ Personal feedback
- ✓ Writing correction
- ✓ Speaking guidance
- ✓ Mock tests
- ✓ Accountability
- ✓ Ongoing adjustment
- ✓ Personalised support

! WHY IT HAPPENS

You don't *need* a program to improve. But if you know your problem and still can't fix it alone, a structure and a teacher who corrects your work can save months of guessing.

Two ways to work with me

12-Week Band 7+ Roadmap Mentorship

Small batch · 3 months · 10 students only

Structured weekly classes, feedback and a clear plan. Good if you like routine and a group.

[See details p.36](#)

1-Month 1-to-1 Live Crash Course

Personal · 1 month · 4 classes per week

Fully personalised, faster pace. Good if you're short on time or have a deadline.

[See details p.37](#)

▶ START HERE

Not ready? Try the **Free Writing Evaluation** first (page 38). No commitment.

NEXT STEP • THE PROGRAM

12-Week **Band 7+** Roadmap Mentorship Program

Strategy. Correction. Accountability.

Designed for serious IELTS students aiming for Band 7+

Duration

3 Months

Classes

3 / week

Class length

90 min

Batch size

10 only

Target band

7+

What you get

- ✓ Detailed mastery of all 4 IELTS modules
- ✓ 3-month step-by-step study plan
- ✓ 5 full mock tests
- ✓ Personal writing correction
- ✓ Speaking feedback sessions
- ✓ Weekly progress reports
- ✓ WhatsApp support group
- ✓ Personal IELTS material pack
- ✓ After-course support available
- ✓ Exclusive completion certificate

PROGRAM FEE

Regular: BDT 9,999

FOUNDING BATCH OFFER

BDT 7,999

Only 10 seats available.

Your teacher

IELTS Overall Band 8 (CLB 9)

Pearson Edexcel IGCSE English:

Grade 9

100+ students taught

Author, IELTS DECODED book series

Professional IELTS instructor

! HOW IT CONNECTS

How it builds on this guide: the diagnostic becomes your weekly plan. Your Mistake Log gets reviewed by a teacher. Your Writing and Speaking get real feedback instead of self-checking.

▶ HOW TO JOIN

Message on WhatsApp: 01305273703

Send **ENROLL** for mentorship details, or **WRITE** for a free writing evaluation.

NEXT STEP

Prefer 1-to-1? The Crash Course

Page 37 →

NEXT STEP · THE PROGRAM

1 Month 1-to-1 Live IELTS Crash Course

Personalised. Focused. Fast improvement.

For students who want maximum improvement in minimum time, through completely personalised live mentoring.

Duration

1 Month

Classes

4 per week

COURSE FEE

BDT 9,999

Target band 7+

Class length

90 min

Mode

1-to-1 Live

What you get

- ✓ Complete Reading strategy
- ✓ Complete Listening strategy
- ✓ Complete Writing strategy
- ✓ Complete Speaking strategy
- ✓ Personal study plan
- ✓ Personal writing correction
- ✓ Speaking feedback every week
- ✓ Live screen-sharing sessions
- ✓ Vocabulary & templates
- ✓ Band score tracking
- ✓ Weekly progress reports
- ✓ Resource library
- ✓ Homework after every class
- ✓ WhatsApp support
- ✓ Mock tests
- ✓ Personalised weakness analysis

Why personal mentorship?

- Every class is designed around **your** weaknesses
- Choose class times that suit you
- No waiting for other students
- Every mistake corrected immediately
- 100% teacher attention in Speaking

Perfect for

- ✓ Students with Band 5.5–6.5
- ✓ Students applying abroad
- ✓ Last-minute IELTS preparation
- ✓ Busy professionals
- ✓ University and scholarship applicants



HOW TO JOIN

Message on WhatsApp: 01305273703 and send **CRASH** to reserve a slot.

NEXT STEP

Ready to stop guessing?

Page 38 →

READY TO STOP GUESSING?

Start with the system.

Know your weakness.

Work on the right thing.

Get feedback.

Track your progress.

FREE IELTS WRITING EVALUATION

Send your **Writing Task 2 introduction** and receive:

- ✓ Estimated band score
- ✓ Structure feedback
- ✓ Grammar feedback
- ✓ Vocabulary feedback
- ✓ Improvement suggestions

Message

WRITE

free writing evaluation

Message

ENROLL

12-week mentorship details

Message

CRASH

1-to-1 crash course slot

WhatsApp

01305273703

IELTS DECODED

Jubayer Siddiki Ayan

IELTS Overall 8 · L8.5 | R8.5 | W7 | S7